

## ***Aberdeen Group Flash Report: High Availability Marketing Messages***

This report is the result of a meeting held on October 28, 1998 with Jim Murphy, Grant Dodson, Jody Stiely, Gary Price, Bonnie Rogers, Wesley Sawyer, John Atwell, and Jennifer Carr of Hewlett-Packard. Attending for Aberdeen Group, Inc. were Peter Kastner, Thomas Willmott, and John Logan.

### **Summary**

Aberdeen Group field research confirms that a large minority (40%-plus) of commercial server buyers consider availability as an important buying attribute. This research includes both the NT and Unix markets. HP's proposal to use high availability (HA) as a major computing message is in alignment with buyer's concerns.

High availability, per se, is a ho-hum message. All market-leaders pay at least some attention in their messages to high availability. Therefore, HP must make its HA message and market position stand out as clearly differentiated and superior to the competition.

Three competitive differentiators that could be used to achieve such a differentiated position include:

- A focus on *end-to-end HA* as opposed to box-level HA that everybody else talks about
- Uptime commitments as contractual guarantees, perhaps with insurance
- High Availability Observatory (HAO) remote monitoring.

### **Market Considerations**

1. HA covers more than high-end Unix servers. HP must ensure that its HA messages include both Unix and NT, directly sold and indirectly sold channels, and, where practical, mainstream ISV applications. In addition, the "end-to-end" concept dictates more and deeper relationships such as that with Cisco and EMC.
2. At this time, no single HP product can improve HA over *both* the NT and Unix platforms. The lack of an NT version of MCservice Guard will not be fixed for technology reasons. Therefore, the NT HA story will have to be part reassurance that "HP is doing everything practical to improve on Microsoft's base platform, and that base platform, services, practices, and remote management can improve NT availability levels." Longer term, NT and Unix products and services should approach parity. In 1999 and 2000, HP must clearly tell the market what the limits are for HA on Intel/NT.
3. For a market-leading HA campaign, Aberdeen would recommend the acquisition of NT fault-tolerance provider, Marathon Technologies. Such an acquisition would give HP the industry's only "FT on NT" capability — a capability that can leverage much more in systems and service revenues than just the FT boxes because the buyers will strongly consider using HP for all of the application's servers and infrastructure.

4. HP's single-Unix-system availability story is average today based on the September 1998 clustering white paper by DH Brown and conceded by the HA marketing team. However, improvements in 1999 will make HP's offering on single systems more competitive. In the interim, Aberdeen recommends that HP consider bundling in MCservice Guard as the lowest level of HA – thereby improving the competitive picture against Sun and IBM.
5. End-to-end HA almost requires that ISV applications plug into the HP HA infrastructure. To an ISV, this represents a significant investment in a HP-only version of the ISV's software – a generally unpalatable investment.
6. While “high availability” resonates with a large market segment, Aberdeen does not believe that HP's “five nines” message is understood by nearly as wide an audience; the *lowest* understanding for five nines would be in the critical line-of-business executive and CEO/CFO/COO management categories. Aberdeen recommends a transition away from the techie-term “five nines” and towards a broader and better understood “end-to-end high availability” super-message.
7. The HA application space should be painted with a broad brush. It is significantly wider than just Unix OLTP, the current focus of HP's HA marketing. HP will gain the greatest advantage by widening the HA umbrella to include *user-defined* mission-critical applications that include e-mail, data warehouses, e-business, supply chain, and call centers. The vertical focus of HA starts with telcos, finance, and retail in-store systems.
8. Aberdeen believes that the “end-to-end HA” theme is credible. HP already has considerable experience over time in this space. Second, Aberdeen sees a 12-18 month useful window for the end-to-end-HA umbrella message – a respectable life. Third, HP's HA advantage has a high level of services components, raising the bar for box-technology-only competitors such as Sun and Compaq. Overall, Aberdeen Group rates HP's end-to-end HA position as defensible and sustainable.
9. Competitively:
  - IBM clearly understands the technologies but has not said anything about HA on its four disparate hardware platforms nor has IBM made any market moves towards end-to-end beyond custom projects by Global Services.
  - Sun is focused on single-box HA issues. Sun is poor-to-fair in a cluster, lacks global services comparable to IBM and HP, and lacks any concept of end-to-end.
  - Compaq has limited its HA thrust to rack-mounted clusters. The Digital services capability is not widely deployed in HA, and Compaq has not worked on end-to-end. While the Tandem division of Compaq certainly understands HA issues in depth, Tandem is presently focused on selling to its installed base with no likely change in that focus.

## 2024 Metadata

Here are my outputs for the 1998 HP high availability document:

### 1. A concise summary of the findings:

The document is a report from a meeting between HP and Aberdeen Group analysts discussing HP's plans to market high availability (HA) as a major selling point. It confirms buyer demand for HA and provides recommendations for HP's HA marketing strategy, including focusing on end-to-end HA, uptime guarantees, remote monitoring, supporting both NT and Unix, and widening the HA umbrella beyond just Unix databases.

### 2. Summary of how buyers should react:

The document argues that a large minority of commercial server buyers (40%+) consider availability an important factor. It recommends HP take an "end-to-end HA" positioning that is differentiated from competitors who only offer box-level HA. Buyers should look for HA capabilities that span the full IT infrastructure, not just individual servers. The document suggests buyers may value contractual uptime guarantees and remote monitoring services.

### 3. Analysis on the technology and its relevance in 2024:

In 2024, high availability remains crucial, especially for cloud and edge computing workloads. However, the scope has expanded beyond just servers to include applications, networks, storage, and full-stack observability. Techniques like multi-cloud redundancy, serverless, and site reliability engineering enable high availability at scale.

While specific 1998 technologies like NT clustering are obsolete, the core principles of redundancy, failover, and holistic monitoring are still highly relevant. Modern HA draws from disciplines like chaos engineering and AI ops for self-healing systems. The "end-to-end" mindset advocated in 1998 prefigured today's site reliability approaches.

### 4. Impact on company histories:

The document captures HP navigating a critical industry transition - the rise of Windows NT servers alongside Unix, creating a need for multi-platform HA solutions. HP's HA marketing focus likely helped drive sales of high-end servers and services in the late 90s.

However, HP faced disruption from web-scale pioneers like Google who rebuilt availability into their cloud-native architectures. HP's enterprise dominance waned as it struggled to adapt quickly enough to utility computing models.

The report's recommendation to acquire NT fault-tolerance vendor Marathon is interesting - had HP executed that play, it may have accelerated its transition to an OS-agnostic HA provider competing with future virtualization/cloud vendors.

#### 5. Market acceleration catalysts:

- Increasing reliance on always-on digital services
- Growth of e-commerce and 24/7 workloads
- Emergence of web-scale computing and cloud providers
- Proliferation of distributed systems and microservices
- AI/ML driving demand for high-performance, available infrastructure

#### 6. Keywords:

High availability, end-to-end, uptime, redundancy, failover, monitoring, fault tolerance, mission critical, service level agreements, cloud native, HP

#### Citations:

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